Education, employability and skills must be connected if we are serious about changing young people's lives.

I welcome the themes emerging from Education Secretary Lucy Powell's speech at the Confederation of School Trusts (CST) Conference 2026, particularly the emphasis on widening opportunities, strengthening vocational education and creating better connections between education, employers and local communities.

For those of us working across employability and skills, there are some important messages here.
After more than 20 years working in this sector, I firmly believe that we cannot tackle youth unemployment and economic inactivity by treating education, skills, health and employment as separate challenges.
They are interconnected, and our response must be too.

◇ Education must open doors, not create barriers.

Recognising technical and vocational qualifications alongside academic routes is an important part of ensuring young people can access pathways that reflect their strengths, interests and aspirations. Success should not be defined by a single qualification or educational route.

◇ Prevention must start early.

Supporting young people who are not in education, employment or training (NEET) cannot begin only when they leave school. Early intervention, effective careers guidance, family support and timely access to specialist services can make a significant difference before challenges become entrenched.

◇ Employers must be part of the solution.

Stronger partnerships between schools, colleges and employers can help young people understand the world of work, develop essential skills, gain meaningful work experience and see realistic routes into sustainable employment.

◇ Inclusion must be central to delivery.

Young people with special educational needs and disabilities, care-experienced young people, those experiencing homelessness and those facing multiple

disadvantages may need more than a standard education or employment offer. They need personalised support, trusted relationships and services that respond to their individual circumstances.

- **Local partnerships must translate ambition into action.**

National policy can establish the direction, but meaningful change depends on effective collaboration locally. Schools, colleges, local authorities, combined authorities, employers, health services, community organisations and specialist employability providers all have a role to play.

We need to move beyond fragmented provision towards a genuinely integrated system in which information is shared appropriately, support is coordinated, and young people do not fall through the gaps between services.

- **Outcomes must mean more than numbers.**

Qualifications and employment figures matter, but so do confidence, wellbeing, essential skills, progression and sustained employment. We must understand the individual journey, not simply count the final destination.

At Compass Consult (Employability & Skills) Ltd, our belief is that better connections between people, organisations and services can help unlock potential and create more effective pathways into learning and work.
The challenge now is implementation.

How do we turn the ambition for greater inclusion, stronger vocational pathways and more connected local services into practical delivery, clear accountability and measurable improvements in young people's lives?

Every young person deserves the opportunity to fulfil their potential, regardless of their background, circumstances or postcode.

That requires more than good intentions. It requires partnership, investment, innovation and a shared commitment to making the system work around the individual.
The conversation between education, skills and employability has never been more important.

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🔗 Read the Education Secretary's full speech: https://www.gov.uk/government/speeches/education-secretary-speech-at-cst-conference-2026

What more needs to happen to connect education, employers and employability services so that every young person has a meaningful pathway into a positive future?